

Episode 88: Once Upon a Time... (52) – Colours Created! The Secret of BG-2A, BG-3A, and CR-1A, CR-2A

From last week through this week, there was a big move in the colour design room at Toei Animation's (東映アニメーション) Oizumi Studio. Since I became freelance, the room was divided into a room for freelance people and others. And with that came the big move. And personal organisation, major cleanup.

What I thought was just recently turned out to be over 15 years since I moved into the current room. In that time, I accumulated so much stuff that I reset everything and disposed of a tremendous variety of things.

I kept only commemorative works' storyboards and setting materials from old works, discarding the rest. I discarded old reference magazines and books including manga that had become outdated. I discarded all MO discs (!) containing early digital work data (←the data had been converted to CDs long ago). Personal music recordings on cassette tapes and MD discs were also discarded.

I was amazed at the sheer volume of items that had been placed around this desk area (laughs).

At the same time, various things were "excavated"!

There were mountains of main production materials related to *Coo: Far From Home* that I'm writing about now. And looking at such things made me lose track of time, so cleanup wouldn't progress, wouldn't progress (laughs).

Still, I somehow forced myself to clean up and successfully created a "new nest" (laughs).

"From now on, I'm going to live as lightly as possible!" - so I vowed (laughs).

Now then.

"Then let's make them."

"Huh? Is that okay?" said I.

"You can't do it with existing paints, right? Then let's have the paint company make them. This is such a big theatrical work."

The colour of the crucial protagonist Coo in the theatrical work *Coo: Far From Home* absolutely wouldn't be decided. With the paints available at Toei Animation, the colour tone was impossible. Then this surprising development occurred suddenly.

This development honestly surprised me. Actually, I had been thinking "that's the only method, isn't it?" but I thought "well, it's probably impossible."

I had tried searching for suitable paints among Taiyo Shikisai paints that Toei Animation didn't basically use, but even with Taiyo Shikisai's extensive colour range, the colours usable for Coo's body were also subtle. But I was thinking that maybe in the end I'd have to have the director compromise somewhere around there.

The fundamental reason for being cautious about making new paints was that ultimately, increasing colours meant extra money.

At that time, professional cel colouring paints in large business bottles (called "kilo bottles") cost 2000 yen per bottle for STAC (incidentally, Taiyo Shikisai was about 1600 yen). These had to be stocked at studios handling colouring work. Since the character requiring these new colours was the "protagonist" Coo, naturally he appeared most frequently, so it wouldn't end with one or two bottles - large quantities had to be prepared. If this increased to 3 colours, 4 colours and beyond, costs would increase accordingly.

Colouring work was a per-piece world. Even for theatrical works, Toei work's contract rates were probably around 300 yen per piece (maybe a bit higher?). Paint costs and such were included in that amount. So when the paints used (prepared) increased, production became that much more difficult.

"Then why not supply the needed new colours in kind as needed?" - I would think, but "material costs are included in the unit price," and somehow the company side wouldn't budge on that point (laughs).

Also, at that time, the centre of Toei works' colouring operations was gradually shifting to a studio in Manila, Philippines. At that time, all cels and paints for Manila studios were sent from Japan by sea mail - a time-consuming system (though industrial products that could be made locally like cut bags were made locally). So if paint ran short during production, it would be terrible, so large quantities had to be sent anticipating surpluses.

The new colours made this time would only be usable for COO production, and these colours wouldn't remain on Toei Animation's colour chart for use in any work in the future. For such reasons, "increasing new 'colours'" was in a sense a production taboo.

But we decided to make them anyway. While the aforementioned issues certainly existed, from the position of deciding colours, this was an unprecedented great opportunity.

"List up how many you'll need."

When told that, naturally "necessary colours" transform into "desired colours" (laughs). So the colours I listed, even after cutting down, were about 10 colours. I submitted this to the company... but as generally expected, things got cloudy (laughs). Apparently there was indeed various debate among higher-ups in the production department, and the

result was "10 colours is too many!" - the list was returned (laughs). But it wasn't completely rejected - with the condition "minimum," it became possible.

"Well, I suppose so," said I. I had honestly anticipated such a situation (laughs). So I resubmitted a list of 4 colours that were absolutely essential new colours, and somehow got the go-ahead.

Those 4 colours were: first, 2 colours for "Coo's" body colour. Coo's body would be painted in two colours - upper and lower surfaces - the upper surface normal colour and regular shadow colour. I mixed existing BG-series paints to make sample amounts and painted colour samples, getting the director's approval. These were given to the paint company for production. They were named BG-2A and BG-3A respectively.

And 2 more colours. These were "Cathy's" skin colours.

Cathy was a white woman tanned brown, but Toei's paints didn't have suitable paints. The limited variety of skin colour variations in Toei's paints was truly fatal. So, I'll confess here for the first time, I plotted something a bit sneaky.

The newly made colours were CR-1A and CR-2A. Actually, these 2 colours were Taiyo Shikisai paint colours 56N (←probably) and 45M. I made colour samples using these 2 Taiyo Shikisai paint colours I personally owned and had STAC make them.

While the new colours were supposedly "only for COO production," I thought:

"Since we'll probably make too many and have leftovers anyway, and if there are leftovers it's wasteful, so it's better to use them for other works too, right? (grin)"

Regardless of Coo's body colours, these brownish skin-tone intermediate colours were colours I definitely wanted to use for works other than COO, especially video works. Even if I couldn't use them openly, if I used them secretly to an unnoticed degree, it

would be fine - I had such calculations. And if they ran short by any chance, I could just use Taiyo Shikisai paints directly.

Actually, from *COO* onward, these 2 colours continued to be used "secretly" in quite a few works I participated in (laughs).

Also, there were production systems like the theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* I had participated in before entering *COO*, where during crunch time we'd do colour direction with Taiyo Shikisai colours and have Korean studios do the colouring - I thought these could be used in such cases too!

So we could use 4 new colours.

While there were only these 4 colours for heavy use as new colours, I thought that probably during colour direction work, there would be colours I'd want to use like "just here! just this cut!" depending on the cut. In such cases, I could either add paint I made myself to colouring orders cut by cut, or have it ordered from colouring studios that had Taiyo Shikisai paints - I was determined to use every possible means.

Thus *Coo: Far From Home* was able to establish a system for creating "colours" using the highest number of colours in Toei Animation work history.

And finally we'd enter the real production of main episode screens.

(09.04.21)